



CAPITALISATION

Knowing which words always need a capital letter

1 What is it?

Capitalisation (kap-it-uh-ly-ZAY-shun)

Capitalisation means using a capital letter for certain words — always at the start of a sentence, for the pronoun 'I', and for proper nouns such as names, places, days, months and titles.

sentence starts / 'I' / proper nouns = capital letter

2 See it in action

Sentence start

"**We** are ready to begin."

The pronoun I

"Sam and **I** walked to school."

Names & places

"**Aisha** lives in **London** and studies at **Greenfield School**."

Days & months

"We return on **Monday** in **September**, but autumn is my favourite season."



Good spot!

If you're unsure, ask yourself: is this the start of a sentence, the word 'I', or the name of something specific? If yes, it needs a capital.

3 More to know

Titles

"**Charlie** and the **Chocolate Factory**"

Acronyms

"**BBC** stands for the British Broadcasting Corporation."

FUN FACT

Seasons — spring, summer, autumn, winter — are never capitalised in everyday writing, even though days and months always are, unless a season appears in a title, like a fashion brand's 'Spring 2021 collection'.

4 Why it's used

Capitalisation helps: signal to the reader exactly where a sentence begins and which words are specific names rather than general ones — it's one of the clearest markers of careful, accurate writing.

Capital letters also apply to titles of books, films and songs (capitalise the important words, like *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*), and to acronyms like BBC or NASA, which are almost always written in full capitals.



Quick reminder!

Job titles only get a capital when they're used as part of someone's actual name, like President Mujica, not when they're used generally, like 'the next president'.

5 Where you'll spot it

After punctuation

After a semicolon, keep lowercase unless the next word is a proper noun. After a colon introducing a list, also keep lowercase.

With quotation marks

Capitalise the first word of a quote only if it's a complete sentence — He said, "This is brilliant." but she called it "a great idea."

⚠ Watch out!

Don't capitalise a common noun unless it's part of a specific name — "I went to the park" stays lowercase, but "I visited Hyde Park" needs a capital because Hyde Park is a specific, named place.

6 Quick recap

Start of every sentence

The pronoun 'I', always

Proper nouns: names, places, titles



Keep going!

Family words like mum, dad or aunt only get a capital when used as a name on their own — 'Can I go, Dad?' — not when there's a 'my' or 'the' in front of them.